*A charcoal-pot and a pair of bellows.*

When the project was about a year old, Defence Minister Krishna Menon made one of his routine visits to ADE. I escorted him into our assembly shop. Inside, on a table lay the GEM model broken down into sub-assemblies. The model represented the culmination of one year's untiring efforts to develop a practical hovercraft for battlefield applications. The minister fired one question after another at me, determined to ensure that the prototype would go into test flight within the coming year. He told Dr Mediratta, "GEM flight is possible with the gadgets Kalam now possesses".

The hovercraft was christened Nandi, after the bul ridden by Lord Shiva. For a prototype, its form, fit and finish was beyond our expectation, given the rudimentary infrastructure we possessed. I told my col eagues, "Here is a flying machine, not constructed by a bunch of cranks but by engineers of ability. Don't look at it—it is not made to look at, but to fly with."

Defence Minister Krishna Menon flew in the Nandi, overruling the accompanying officials' concern for his safety. A Group Captain in the minister's troupe, who had